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SPARK AI

A BRIEF INTRODUCTION and OVERVIEW

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Director
https://sparkai.network/

OVERVIEW

Concept

Establish a senior-level forum of industry, academic and public sector leaders to facilitate peer engagement, knowledge exchange, and the development of specialized, purpose-built research and education

Mission

To advance AI knowledge, strategy and practice to achieve business success and competitive advantage, and to influence the development of modern, transparent and trustworthy regulatory policy, implementation and corporate governance

People and Organization

SPARK is a diverse, independent, and interdisciplinary group dedicated to advancing frontier artificial intelligence and addressing underserved areas of AI research and education

SPARK operates within the San Diego Supercomputer Center (SDSC), an Organized Research Unit (ORU) within UCSD - a University-established academic entity designed to provide focused, advanced high-performance computing (HPC) systems in support of inter-, cross-, and multi-disciplinary research across the University and its external partners

2025 Working Papers

Vol 1 No 1: Is AI Governable? Industry Perspectives on the Adoption, Effectiveness and Accountability of Frontier AI
James Short

Vol 1 No 2: Meeting Agentic AI's Data Quality Needs with Zero Trust Data Quality
James Massa and James Short

Vol 1 No 3: Project Chainwatch: A User Configurable Anomaly Detection System for Monitoring Blockchain Network Data Flows
Samson Qian, Steve Orrin, Matt Clanton and James Short

Vol 1 No 4: Scientifically Automating Data Quality Decisions with AI Explainability Weights
James Massa and James Short

Vol 1 No 5: Building Intelligent Foundations: Rethinking Storage Strategy in the Age of AI
James Short

Vol 1 No 6: Revolutionizing Drug Discovery with AI-Driven Semantic Data Engineering
Joe Lancaster, Murali Krishnam, Raju Puspati and James Short

2026 Projects Under Consideration

Micro-Gains, Macro-Patience: Assessing Agentic AI Productivity

Agentic AI has fueled expectations of rapid productivity improvements and significant economic impact. Empirical studies show early-stage micro-level gains, such as faster task execution, fewer errors, and more consistent outputs. However, these micro-level improvements have not translated into measurable macroeconomic effects. Why?

Will Automation Replace Your Workforce?

Every major information-based technology in the last half-century has displaced legacy tasks, reorganized firms, and changed skill premiums. In the 1970s, relational databases and transaction processing drove large-scale automation of clerical, accounting, inventory, payroll, and logistics work, triggering major displacements of white-collar workers. Today, there is little new or novel in the contention that AI will trigger workforce displacement or materially adjust skill premiums. A more important question is how quickly, and in what ways, will fully automated systems increasingly displace higher-skill level work functions, removing human intervention from the operational workflow, and relegating governance to post-hoc observation and assessment

When Expectations Count: Prediction Markets, Expertise, and Forecasting AI Trajectories

Forecasts of AI progress are numerous, yet there is little consensus on measurement or prediction. This project examines prediction markets as a mechanism for aggregating diverse projections about AI trajectories. Special attention will be given to the composition of market participants—domain experts, generalists, and financially motivated forecasters—to address how incentives shape prediction behavior. The study aims to clarify the conditions under which prediction markets provide calibrated insights into AI progress and uncertainty

Engagement

Three Levels

Community

Open, informational site: announcements, events, selected content, peer networking

Free with registration on the SPARK website

Executive Forum

Designed for small and medium sized businesses, public services, .edu partners

Organized as a peer level discussion forum, supported by quarterly events, ad hoc briefings and workshops, and access to specialized research, including POV, Intelligence Briefings, and Center working papers

Three tiers based on ARR: Start ups ($5K) Mid ($10K) Enterprise ($15K)

Applied Research Center (ARC)

Organized by project and program research, sole or multi-company sponsored

Bottom-up, early-stage research studies focused on feasibility and proof of concept

Each project delivers purpose-built reports and co-designed briefings or workshop outputs

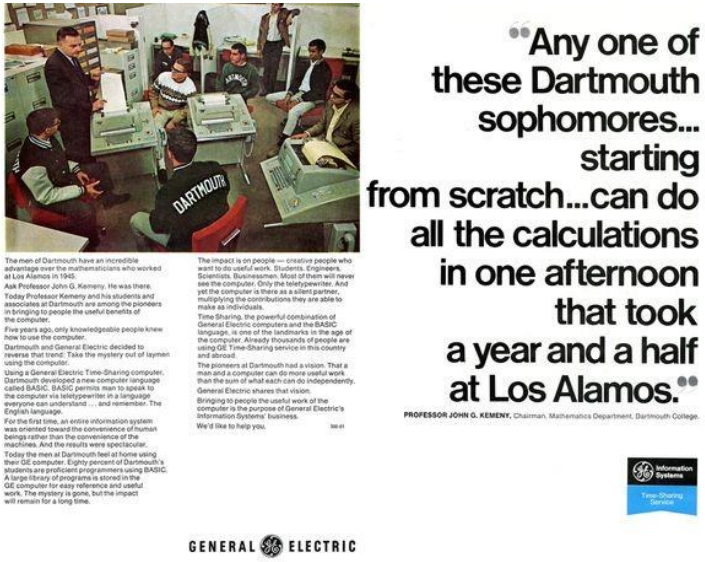
Baseline ARC sponsorship is $25K. Project budgets are purpose-built by time, scope, team, outputs

Contact Dr. James Short, SPARK Director, for ARC inquiries (jshort@sdsc.edu)

Get to Know the SPARK Ecosystem

- **Join the Free Community**
  - Register as Community Member on the SPARK website
  - Look Around, Join Selected Virtual Events
  - Get Access to Selected Content
- **Join the Member Forum**
  - Participate directly in SPARK Activities, Discussion Groups, Events
  - Get access to Member and selected ARC content
  - Join SPARK in writing about AI. Forum Members can write and submit content for review and posting on the SPARK website
    - POV and Intelligence Briefings
    - Authors can create discussion groups around their work, host virtual workshops, etc.
- **Join the ARC (Applied Research Center)**
  - Design a specialized feasibility study or educational activity starting with base level funding. Do this as an individual company, or in partnership with other companies or advisors in the community
  - Consider underwriting a larger effort that includes a student team and/or SDSC research scientists and/or participating faculty

For Further Information



Source: Computer History Museum, Exhibition, The Virtues of Sharing, GE Timesharing at Dartmouth https://computerhistory.org/

Consult the Consortium website at: https://sparkai.network/

Contact the Director, James Short, at jshort@sdsc.edu